

*Weak thought and Deep Listening. An intersection between Gianni Vattimo and
free improvisation*

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*Since I cannot rise to a state of being, nor collapse into nothingness
I have to listen more than ever, I have to look around me.*

-Jean-Luc Goddard, *2 or 3 Things I Know About Her* (1967)

INTRODUCTION

In the chapter: “Freedom and peace in the postmodern condition” of *Nihilism and Emancipation*, Vattimo clarifies the apparent dangers of the imminent loss of values and absolutes that nihilism brings with it, however it is right here where he proposes that the freedom and plurality that this unleashing implies, can and hopefully will lead us to peace. For Vattimo, metaphysics and its stability, which would be what nihilism comes to end with, would always imply a state of violence, since it seeks to eradicate whatever lies outside of its determinations and reduces strictly the discussion around absolutes. With the end of metaphysics and despite the apparent chaos that this ending implies, we could finally end this violence as well. Vattimo explains that the freedom that occurs in postmodernism would imply the emergence of two options: either we become purely and simply relativists or we develop a post-metaphysical ethics. Vattimo leans towards the second. This post-metaphysical ethics would have its foundation in what Vattimo calls weak thought, that would be a way of understanding a

new edifying philosophy that is based on hermeneutics instead of determinacy and objective truth. In this essay I will explain how this weak thought is deeply connected to the notion of listening, which Vattimo rescues from Heidegger and from religious practices such as of Christianity. For that I will explain how the concept of listening is connected and interwoven with other concepts in Vattimo's work such as otherness and kenosis.

With this essay I want to explore how certain practices within art not only increase this weakening of thought, but also give us tools to improve this listening and broaden the scope of it within our communities. I find the practice of free improvisation particularly akin and relevant in the dialogue with Vattimo, which is why I will explore the concept of Deep Listening in improvisation, developed by the composer and accordionist Pauline Oliveros and I will compare it with Vattimo's notion of listening. To later explain why I believe also that if we incorporate this type of practices, our notion of situatedness can become more complex by also incorporating our attention to sound through our body, and what implications this would have in our relation and interlocution with others.

SITUATEDNESS, ETHICS AND THE ONTOLOGY OF THE PRESENT

Vattimo follows the path that was already traced by Kant, this path is that of the critique of the present. I will briefly explain what this critique of the present (also understood as an analytics of finitude by Michel Foucault or as an ontology of the present by Vattimo), consists of. Although it seems that in the three Kantian critiques there is no recognition of the transcendental subject within history, Kant is strongly interested in the subject's relationship with its present and this can be seen particularly in his 1784 essay *What is Enlightenment?*. Furthermore, in *Anthropology from a Pragmatic Point of View*, he would start trying to find an incorporation of his three critiques into history.

In *What is Enlightenment?*, Kant raises the existence of a state of man, within which he found himself and outside of which a successful modernity would manage to

lead him to. This state is that of a minority of age, in which we do not have the power to use our reason to conduct our own actions, that is, we give command of our actions to an authority whose reasoning capacity we consider superior. Kant explains, when wondering about his present, that the Enlightenment consists of the moment in which men pass from the state of minority of age to one of greater autonomy. The *Anthropology*, on the other hand, is an analysis of finitude and its objective is to think about the finiteness of man in his relationship with the world and with himself through language. Finitude would be understood as the limits of man, but not the external limits, but the limits that he gives himself, that he applies to his experience and to the objects of experience. In the *Anthropology* there would be a question no longer about what man is, but about what he makes and what he *can* make of himself. In both *What is Enlightenment?* and *Anthropology from a Pragmatic Point of View*, Kant would propose the need to have a critical attitude towards our present and the limits that come with it. In the *Introduction* that he writes for the *Anthropology*, Michel Foucault says the following:

[T]he aim of anthropology is to situate man within this instructive context. It will therefore be both, indissociably: the analysis of how man acquires the world (his use, rather than his knowledge of it), which is to say how he manages to take his place in the world and participate in the game: *Mitspielen*; and, at the same time, the synthesis of the prescriptions and rules that the world imposes on man, which train him, readying him to take control of the game: *das Spiel verstehen*. Anthropology is therefore neither a history of culture nor an analysis of its successive forms, but the practice, at once immediate and imperative, of a culture already given in advance.¹

This critical attitude towards the own present and finitude this recognition of the self imposed limits, would permeate, as Vattimo notes, in several of later philosophical

¹ Foucault, *Introduction to Kant's Anthropology*, pp. 53-54

projects, such as those of Nietzsche, Foucault, Heidegger and even in Vattimo himself.²

Recognizing that and how our existence is situated in a certain historical moment would be of great importance for Vattimo's ethics. Our actions can no longer depend on those great and absolute values, but are completely our responsibility, and it is necessary, in order to take charge of these actions, first to understand how our actions are already conditioned in some way by our particular situation. As Vattimo says: "it might be objected that if there are no universal supreme first principles, then the only things that would seem to count are the imperatives dictated by specific situations."³ The situation that determines us would be both in our history and in our finitude, that is, our death, in the same way it must be understood as a situation that concerns us both as individuals and as a group of individuals.

However, this situatedness cannot be converted into a new absolute value either and that is where, according to Vattimo, the difference between post-metaphysical ethics and pure relativism would lie. Acknowledging our situation and situatedness allows us to understand where our limits lie, our situation is part of the horizon of meaning from which we move in the world. But Vattimo recognizes that if we gave an absolute value to this situation this would be to return to a metaphysics, to take again "a specific and particular myth as an ideological absolute, as the "real world", which would justify violence again. We cannot say that this situation is what we belong to, since "the situation to which we really belong before all else, and toward which we are responsible in our ethical choices, is that of the dissolution of principles, of nihilism."⁴ A post-metaphysical ethics would imply the need to recognize the situation that determines our decisions, desires and impulses, but at the same time the ability and responsibility to distance ourselves from this situation in order to move in ways other than those dictated by it. It is important to recognize that everyone has their own situation and horizon and it is true that it could seem that this plurality of situations or

² Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation*, p. 36

³ *Ibid*, p. 41

⁴ *Idem*

situated voices and truths could lead to absolute chaos, that is why Vattimo raises the importance of interpretation and listening, because only through these, we can find peace and freedom within plurality. A society in which respect thrives, is a society whose individuals acknowledge their own limits and the limits of the others. "Respect for others is, above all, recognition of the finitude that characterizes all of us and that rules out any complete conquest of the opacity that every person bears."⁵

WEAK THOUGHT AND LISTENING TO THE WEAK

With the occurrence of nihilism, notions such as 'natural', 'true' or 'essential' lose any legitimacy in the affairs of man, and plurality and multiplicity emerge. There is no longer a connection to a nature, an essence or a truth that dictates what man is, and without any foundational structure or ulterior substance it is only possible to accept that each of the different ways of being occupy a space within a great spectrum. As Vattimo explains in his debate with Richard Kearney, we not only have to recognize our situatedness as particular individuals, but also as a community in a history that is not The History (in capital letters) but *our* (hi)story. The institutions of the absolute have written history as if there were a single one, in which each one of the individuals, that plurality now allows us to see, has a space. But for Vattimo, and as we can see, this has not been the case. And this would be exactly where the idea of weak thought takes place. Taking up the Heideggerian project of remembrance of Being, Vattimo proposes that our duty as philosophers is to rethink and remember what has been violently forgotten by the writers of History. In the same debate, he says "Weak thinking (*pensiero debole*), as I formulate it, is a history of remembrance of what has been forgotten."⁶ As a solution to this forgetfulness of being, Vattimo proposes that one must listen to being, listen to what is forgotten, that is, listen to what is weak,

⁵ *Ibid*, p. 47

⁶ The interview is cited in *Critchley*, "Anatheism, Nihilism and Weak Thought" in Kearney's *Reimagining the Sacred*, p. 136.

everything that has been left out of History.⁷ For there to be a revolutionary nihilism, one must have the ability to go beyond one's horizon in order to meet the other, an other that, in most cases, is a silenced and forgotten other. The ontology of actuality is not something that the individual alone does, it involves the other and the others. This attitude requires that we withdraw from the need to impose our horizon on others, it asks us to step back and listen, almost with no expectations. This attitude of listening would be the actual ontology of actuality.⁸

So we should not run away from nihilism, because nihilism is not something that should be overcome, but rather embraced, it is there that we can finally find liberation, and this liberation has two important pillars: (i) weak thought as the weakening of large structures and thought and (ii) weak thought as listening to others. In *Nihilism and Emancipation* Vattimo says:

It comes to see that the emancipation and liberation that mankind has always sought are attainable through a weakening of strong structures, a reduction of claims, and that implies, in general terms, that quality counts for more than quantity, that listening to what others have to say counts for more than measuring objects with precision. In all fields, including science, truth itself is becoming an affair of consensus, listening, participation in a shared enterprise, rather than one-to-one correspondence with the pure hard objectivity of things.⁹

LISTENING AND KENOSIS

In his optimistic project, Vattimo would try to rescue those values of Christianity that still have relevance and power for the edification of a libertarian and peaceful society. It is true that Christianity would have proclaimed several of the absolute values

⁷ *Ibid*, p. 138

⁸ Vattimo, *Being and its Surroundings*, p. 183

⁹ Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation*, p. 35

that with nihilism would have lost their legitimacy, such as guilt, the idea of a god and a world beyond our world, the idea of good and evil, etc. However, Vattimo believes that in Christianity there are also elements that can help us build a post-metaphysical society, non-violent and based on respect and listening to others. In texts like *Belief* and *After Christianity*, he explores the notion of Christian mysticism: *kenosis*, and incorporates it into his project. The meaning of this concept is quite debated within Christian theology, mainly, it can be understood from the Greek term κενόω as an emptying or depletion. The term is used to refer to the humanization of God in Jesus, it is also used to refer to the emptying of desires and opening of Jesus to receive God's will. Both are understood as emptying processes, in one direction or in the other. Vattimo uses the term to refer to the descent of God to the plane of the human, moment in which he, God, is demystified. In *Belief*, he says: “the incarnation of God, the *kenosis* — that is the removal of all the transcendent, incomprehensible, mysterious and even bizarre features that seem to move so many theorists of the leap of faith.” This demystification would be equivalent to the weakening of the truth, because for Vattimo there is still truth and there is still a god, but that truth and that god are no longer found on any plane other than the human plane, on the plane of language and interpretation, of contingency. This weakening of truth would be also the weakening of god. Just as we stopped believing in objective truth, we also stopped believing in God. And it is that we no longer believe, rather we interpret, and it is in hermeneutics, in how we use language to convey and communicate as humans, where we can once again find God and truth, but both demystified. As Daniele Fulvi explains: “for Vattimo truth is always a matter of interpretation in its historical situatedness, from which follows that truth itself is characterized as the opening of new horizons and points of view, and not as a transcendent and immutable occurrence.”¹⁰

Kenosis can also be understood as the withdrawal of the self, and this withdrawal works in both ways, both the withdrawal of god godself, as well as the withdrawal of man to surrender to the will of god. This double withdrawal, as an attitude, should be fundamental characteristic of all dialogue as a hermeneutic encounter, in our relationships to others. For Vattimo it is important to understand that

¹⁰ Daniele Fulvi, “Kenosis and Nature”, p. 59-60

the absolutes are outside of us but also within us, assumed as such, within us there is that voice of the flock that tries to impose itself as truth. We can understand this internalized voice as the residue of metaphysics. Dialogue and interpretation require an opening to the other, and in order to be in this openness to the other, I have to be willing to be invaded by the truth of the other. It is true that I already come to the dialogue with a certain horizon, and I must recognize it, however, I do not claim that my truth and my horizon are *the* truth and *the* horizon, instead I allow the horizon of the other to meet and even, up to a point, merge with mine, in some type of hermeneutic play. In order for there to be a true dialogue, there cannot be a total abandonment of the self that is listening; in the dialogue, both interlocutors are in a game of self-abandonment and self-affirmation, which means that there is a double entrustment of the self and this relationship is necessarily one of hospitality, a placement of oneself in the hands of the other.¹¹ The emptying of *kenosis* would imply that I make space for the other to feel safe enough to entrust themselves into me and in this emptying of the self I empty myself not of my experience or history, my contingent truth, but the belief that my experience or history defines the limits of possible meaning and experience of the other.

This is why, just as God places himself at our level, we must also place ourselves at the level of the other, leaving aside everything that we, through our socialization and our history, have learned as absolute and true. We have to demystify the god incarnated in us as a desire or will to command, as a sovereign. This would imply also a withdrawal of violence towards the other. Fulvi explains very clearly how this *kenotic* “sacrifice” of the self would also imply the weakening of the notion of subjectivity.

kenotic sacrifice becomes essential to withdraw the violence of sacred and absolute truth, showing that the essence of Christianity is not grounded in abstract theological dogmas, but in acknowledging that truth is always a matter of interpretation. Hence, *kenosis* cannot but be inscribed within a hermeneutical account. However, such an account

¹¹ See Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 100

does not entail a form of radical subjectivity: as Vattimo himself points out, “hermeneutics also involves a sort of weakening of subjectivity”, meaning that the process of secularization and weakening of traditional Western metaphysics implies a different conception of subjectivity, according to which the subject is no longer conceived of as that idealized and absolute self-consciousness which is the foundation of “strong” metaphysics.¹²

As we have already mentioned, the truth would now be found at the level of language, but of a language that understands truth as interpretation within the communicative uses of language between subjectivities, between interlocutors. In his interview with Cristián Warnken, Vattimo says that: “if there is a god, he is the god of our freedom, he is the interlocutor of our dialogue and not an absolute necessity at the bottom of reality.”¹³ After the end of the metaphysics, God is no longer anywhere else, but in dialogue and intersubjectivity, and the linguistic and hermeneutic relations between the *I* and *the other* or *the thou*.

In *Listening for the other*, Lisbeth Lipari, philosopher of communication, says, in relation to the ethic and hermeneutic interexchange, that

the ethical relation cannot be reduced either to an act of self-affirmation or to one of selflessness, but instead emerges in the presence of the other. [...] The move to responsibility is governed by response, and the self stands in relation to the other’s otherness. One does not surrender to the other, rather one surrenders to the presence of the intersubjective, a space wherein the self submits to epiphenomenal emergence of the between – the space created by two others engaged in a dialogic I-Thou encounter.¹⁴

¹² *Ibid.*, p. 60

¹³ The interview is published in: *Otro Canal* (16th of May 2022), “Gianni Vattimo - Dios y el Nihilismo. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9q0aQ91r1ek&t=1972s> [The translation is mine]

¹⁴ Lipari, *Listening for the other*, p. 130

When we listen to the other, we are immerse in the field of our interexchange, we both are abandoned to hospitality, an atmosphere of care surrounds us. In relationship to the dialogues between religions and cultures, Vattimo says the following: “If Christian identity, applying the principle of charity, takes the shape of hospitality in the dialogue between religions and cultures, it must limit itself almost entirely to listening, and thus giving voice to the guests.”¹⁵ Listening to the other implies that we are both creating a space for our voices to emerge, voices that are of course bound to a particular (hi)story and a situation, a particular truth. God descends to the plane of human existence and with this, he stops being the unreachable Other, to become simply the other and our the space of our relation to the other through language.

LISTENING AS PRACTICE AND ATTITUDE IN FREE IMPROVISATION

We can now see how the term of listening in Vattimo is much more complex than the mere physical act of hearing. Listening is woven into a complex network of concepts, such as weak thinking, kenosis, otherness and situatedness. Once that we have explained Vattimo's concept of listening and how it is complemented throughout his thought and work, we will talk about free improvisation and its implications in listening. We can find countless examples in which Vattimo expresses himself around listening as part of the elements of his thought and his project, but not so many times we find how this attitude of listening is developed. It might seem that this listening is simply the result of our philosophical good will, but I believe that this open attitude can be propagated and expanded within our communities through different practices, specifically in the practice of free improvisation.

Musical improvisation is the creation in real time of sounds that may or may not be sticking to certain stylistic or harmonic norms. Improvisation goes beyond what written in the music score and asks the performer to create and play freely with sound. Improvisation could be said to have its origins in early music. The figured bass was a very common tool of music writing, which indicated the harmonic changes on which

¹⁵ Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 101

the instrument, which plays the bass in the given set of instruments, can create melodic variations by choice. But it was, centuries later, in jazz where improvisation found a place of special development. In Jazz, the musicians perform an improvised solo with more or less complex melodic variations on the given harmonic structure, this improvisation requires great technical knowledge and skill, as well as an understanding of harmony and how it works in the given piece.

Free improvisation goes a step beyond the mere improvisation that we find in jazz or other academic music. The interpreter is no longer constraint to play within the fixed parameters, such as harmony, structure or style, in free improvisation there are no rules; any note, sound and technique is allowed. It is important to say that in the history of music, as well as art in general, there have also been absolutes and metaphysical ideas. One of the greatest absolutes, and of which Theodor Adorno makes a great criticism within all of his work, is the hierarchy of notes based on a harmonic structure. The musical form or structure has also been one of the great absolutes and we could even say that the fact of using given notes or pitches (do, re, mi, fa, etc.) is already an absolutist idea within music and sound art. It is important to note that the field of art also underwent changes with the death of God. The strongest structures were weakening and the avant-garde movements explored different ways of making music, moving mainly away from the tonality and previously explored allowed techniques. The new technologies also allowed new explorations around sound, which little by little would also lead to an exploration of noise.

Improvisation is however particularly relevant in the midst of all these possibilities within sonic art, because in it, listening has a rather great weight, specifically when it is done within a group of musicians. Whether improvisation happens within certain parameters or outside of them, it always asks the performers to be in an attentive state of listening. It is true that even when a performer plays an instrument, he needs to listen to improve his performance of the work. But in improvisation the result depends on the inter-listening of all the participants. By having more freedom in the result of what he is producing, the interpreter must have an even finer attention to what is happening around him, and not just to what he is doing, but to all the group and each of participants are. This attention is placed in many directions.

During the avant-garde musical movements, some composers began to reflect on listening and the perception of sound in relation to space. One of the composers who dedicated the most time to this reflection was John Cage, who dedicated himself to thinking about how our listening and the different ways of listening shape our being in the world, but also, how the sounds in the world can shape our ways of listening. Cage dedicated a large part of his work to thinking about silence. One of his most famous works, 4'33'', is an exploration of listening within an apparent silence. This work invites us to pay attention to all the sounds that surround us in a spatio-temporal way, not only to those that are destined to be the musical work. Following Cage's ideas regarding listening and its relationship with space, Pauline Oliveros develops the notion of *deep listening*. For Oliveros, sound is a space-time continuum and listening would be the attention we pay to this continuum that allows us to recognize how we are connected with that environment, with that acoustic space. Oliveros applied this idea in several of his improvisational works, in which there is no longer only attention and listening to the other, but to everything else that is not me: otherness, that which surrounds me and to which I am connected. This connection would no longer be a connection of absolute belonging, since we are no longer talking about a rootedness in values such as origin, gender, etc., but rather a connection due to the mere fact of happening at the same time in the same space, of being present, as gerund: *seiend*. We could maybe talk here about a weak belonging.

In free improvisation, through deep listening, a field of exchange and conversation is established. I must listen to what the other says in doing, in playing and I must react to it. Even the moments in which we both play and listen at the same time are the ones that prevail. In the conversation that free improvisation allows, the roles are being reverted all the time, at times I have to listen to the other, at others, I am the one being listened to. and in many others, the majority, I am listening to us to the space between us that emerges through the exchange, through the dialogue. In this interaction the subject-object distinction dissolves. Since we are all reacting and responding to one another. I can also listen to me through the other and the other through from me, as well as to the space-time that contains us and with which we are happening. The act of listening here is no longer a transitive action, that is directed

from a subject to an object, but rather, the interconnection of beings, the relation of beings through intersubjectivity.

The fact that there is no rule, no parameter to obey, allows a free play between the desires and the intentions of the participants, there is nothing else to pay attention to but the other and its intentions, incarnated in sound. Furthermore, the fact that it is not necessary to have any knowledge of certain techniques opens up the practice of improvisation to people who even have no knowledge of music. In several of his performances, Oliveros invites the audience to participate in improvisation and listening sessions. And it is not even necessary to know any instrument, since the invitation is made to participate with any sound that the body or the elements of the environment can promote. In her book *Deep Listening*, Oliveros offers a series of exercises or, as she calls them, meditations, that any person can do. In this meditations, Oliveros invites us in different ways to be more attentive to our body and its surroundings through listening. I believe that this types of exercises can be quite useful to understand our situatedness in an even more complex way, since they make us consider also the dimension of the corporeal and space, as well they allow us to be in a more open and receptive relation to the other while listening to them. Olivero's exercises are intended to improve our body and spatial awareness, in the same way that they propose a more complex listening, or deep listening to what is happening in us and around us. This development would allow us to have a different attention in our exchanges with others, be it improvisation or in our daily interactions. The listening that occurs in free improvisation is a listening that is always open to the other, it is a listening that has no expectations and is willing to work with what it receives, which is why I consider that there is also kenotic listening here. We can also find here a kind of descent, of the musician towards the other musician, since the technique, the desires and the musical decisions that one of them has, are not at all intended to be imposed not only on the other, but also on the other. in the end result. Therefore, listening in free improvisation would imply both kenosis and weakening, since it asks for the withdrawal of the self in the interpreter and is founded in a weak treatment of sound and technique.

CONCLUSION

It is difficult to articulate Vattimo's concepts in a linear way, since we can see, through a reading of his extensive work, that they are rather arranged and interconnected in the form of a network. However, we can see how this notion of listening is relevantly interwoven throughout his project. We can conclude that, above all, this listening would be equivalent to an attitude of weakening and openness towards the other and the other, which is somewhere between an abandonment of the self and an affirmation of the self. This listening can take place within conversational exchanges in our day to day, however, I consider that there are situations and practices, like free improvisation, that ask us to pay more attention, a type of meta-attention, with respect to this exchange. And not only do these practices *ask* something of us, but they can even *teach* us something, not with a pretense of authority, but as an invitation and a proposal to do things that are already within our power, since they only involve our body and our attention. Practices such as free improvisation can lead us to increase intently our sense of listening and also our participation in the community, through the interweaving relationships of listening that takes place between subjects that relate to one another as subjects and not as a subject in front of an object. And it is not a matter of saying that these practices can or should replace our exchanges outside of them, but rather that we must recognize in them the existence of events apparently far from the "real" communicative exchange that can contribute to the necessary skills to improve our listening, wherever it happens.

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